

Italian architect wins a US medal

By Robert Campbell

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Italian architect Renzo Piano is the winner of the 2008 Gold Medal of the American Institute of Architects, it was announced yesterday.

Considered the highest American honor for an architect, the medal usually goes to a US architect. But Piano is the fourth foreign medalist in the last 10 years, as the practice of architecture grows ever more global.

Piano, 70, heads an office of more than 100 persons, the Renzo Piano Building Workshop divided between Genoa and Paris.

Said the AIA in its statement: "Renzo Piano's distinguished architecture has captured admirers around the world for more than 30 years. His work is sculptural, beautiful, technically accomplished and sustainable." The architect won the prestigious Pritzker Prize in 1998.

Piano is best known for his art museums, such as the Menil Collection in Houston, the Beyeler Foundation and the Zentrum Paul Klee in Switzerland, and the Nasher Sculpture Center in Dallas. His renovation/addition to the Morgan Library & Museum in New York opened in 2006.

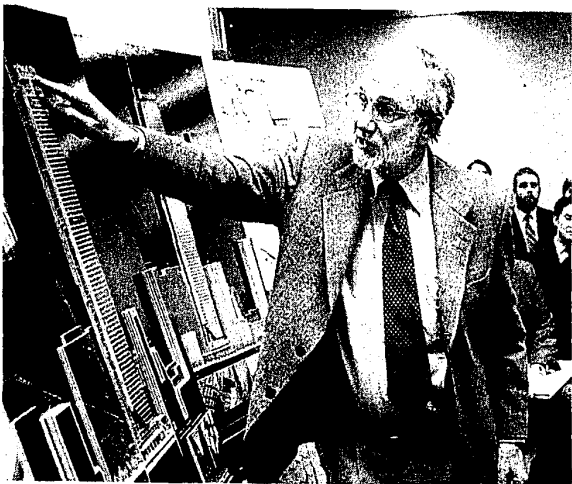
But he has done many types of buildings, including the vast Kansai Airport in Japan and the recently opened New York Times tower in New York.

Piano is currently at work on two commissions in the Boston area. He is the architect for a major renovation and addition to the Fogg Art Museum at Harvard, and for a smaller addition to the Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum in the Fenway. He is also currently doing major additions to the Los Angeles County Art Museum and the Art Institute of Chicago.

Earlier this year, Piano's design for a tower on Winthrop Square downtown, expected to be Boston's tallest building, appeared to be on track to being built. But the architect and the developer, Steve Belkin of Trans National Group, disagreed over the building's proportions and parted ways.

Piano first became known while still in his 20s, when he teamed with British architect Richard Rogers to win a design competition for the Pompidou Center in Paris, which opened in 1977.

The Gold Medal will be formally presented at a gala at the National Building Museum in Washington in February.



WIQAN ANG FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Architect Renzo Piano presents his designs for a tower at a Boston Redevelopment Authority meeting earlier this year.

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